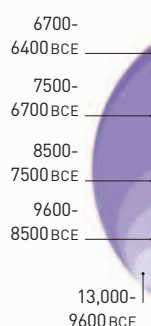




Megalithic (large stone) architecture was used for monumental tombs in Neolithic Europe. Developments around 3300 CE included the construction of stone circles, such as this example at Castlerigg in northern England.



Population density

The population in western Asia grew rapidly from 13,000 to 6400 BCE.

AS STEEPLY RISING TEMPERATURES

between 12,700 and 10,800 BCE melted the northern ice sheets, global sea levels rose, lakes formed, and rainfall increased, promoting the spread of forests and grasslands and providing new opportunities for hunter-gatherer communities.

Coastal areas drowned by rising sea levels were rich sources of aquatic foods, as were lakes and rivers. Grasslands sustained large herds of animals, while forest margins provided abundant plant foods and game. Most hunter-gatherers moved seasonally to exploit the resources of different areas, but particularly favored places such as river estuaries could support people year round. One such region was coastal Peru and Chile, where the cold Humboldt current provides especially rich fisheries.

Settled communities lived here by 7000 BCE, including the Chinchorro, who created the world's first mummies (see panel, opposite).

Another area with favorable conditions was West Asia. Here, vegetation included wild cereals that could be stored, sustaining communities throughout the year when supplemented by other wild foods such as gazelle. A period of cold, arid conditions from 10,800 to 9600 BCE led to a steep

decline in the availability of wild cereals. This prompted some West Asian villagers to turn to cultivation, planting cereals.

Agriculture began in many parts of the world at different times, using local resources. Domesticated plants and animals spread by trade between neighboring groups and when farming communities colonized new areas. Agriculture was not a discovery: hunter-gatherers had a deep knowledge of the plants and animals on which they depended, and often took actions to increase

productivity. Farming was therefore a choice that people made, increasing local productivity, often at the cost of increasing work and risk. Their reasons for farming may have included extending their period of residence in a settled village, providing extra food for feasting or to support a growing population, and boosting the supply of preferred or declining foodstuffs.

Cereals were common staples of early agriculture. Wheat and barley were domesticated in West Asia, spreading into North Africa, Europe, and Central and South Asia. Broomcorn and foxtail millet

were domesticated in the Yellow River valley and rice in the Yangzi valley in China, from where they spread through East and Southeast Asia. In Africa, other millets and African rice were domesticated after 3000 BCE. In the Americas, corn was the principal cereal. However, although it was cultivated by 6000 BCE, it was not until 2000 BCE that corn was sufficiently productive to support permanently settled villages. Legumes and vegetables were grown alongside cereals in many parts of the world.

Tubers, such as manioc and yams, and tree crops were cultivated in moist tropical regions, beginning at an early date in the New Guinea highlands and the rainforests of Central America and northern South America.

Domestic sheep, goats, pigs, and cattle were raised across Eurasia and Africa, initially just for meat. However, in the Americas

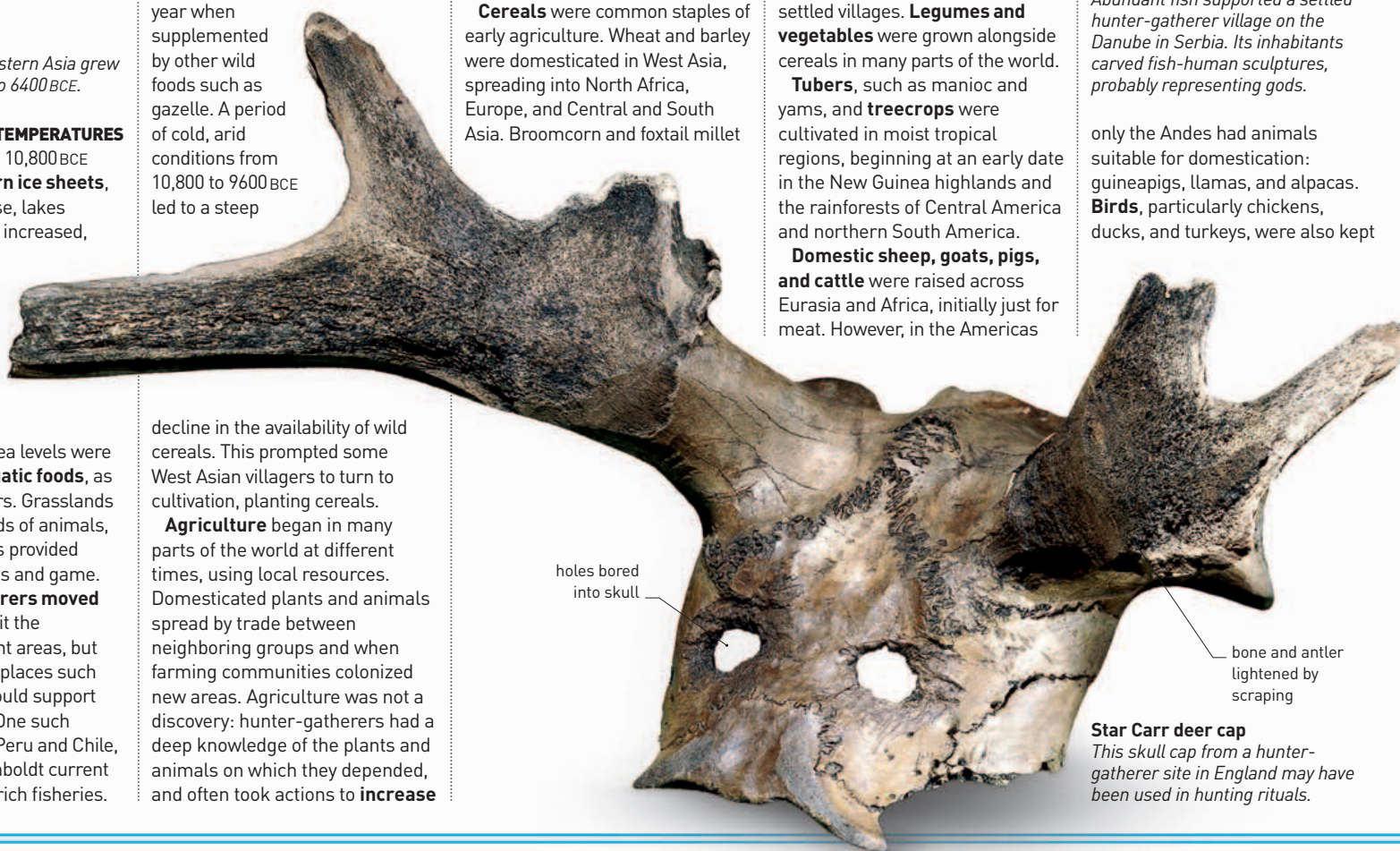


Lepinski Vir "fish god"

Abundant fish supported a settled hunter-gatherer village on the Danube in Serbia. Its inhabitants carved fish-human sculptures, probably representing gods.

only the Andes had animals suitable for domestication: guinea pigs, llamas, and alpacas.

Birds, particularly chickens, ducks, and turkeys, were also kept



holes bored into skull

bone and antler lightened by scraping

Star Carr deer cap

This skull cap from a hunter-gatherer site in England may have been used in hunting rituals.

